



Special moment: Saurav Ghosal secured India's maiden singles squash medal at the Commonwealth Games by clinching bronze in the men's singles event at the 2022 Birmingham Games, triumphing over defending champion James Willstrop of England with a commanding 3-0 victory (11-6, 11-1, 11-4). GETTY IMAGES

When I came back from Chicago at the end of February, I discussed this with my wife, Dia, and my dad.

The tipping point was when I was not continuing to play the PSA even though I loved doing it. I was continuing to play more because I was scared of letting go, having done it for so long. When I realised and accepted that, I felt it couldn't be that I have something that I'm scared of, which is making me stay here. It should be a positive reinforcement rather than a negative one. That's when I said this is going to be very hard, and we're going to step into the unknown in a lot of ways; but you have to do it at some point. Also, understanding that there was no wrong or right time to do this. It was more about me making peace with the decision; whenever I did take it, that was a process that I had to go through, and for the most part, I have made peace with it.

When you play a sport professionally for 20 years, you become accustomed to that routine. Have you considered how you will handle the fear of missing out?

Right now, I love it. That grind is

very tough. One of the things that we discussed was that if I'm going to do this, then I need to get away from the grind for a good four or five months because the mind and the body just need time to heal, rejuvenate, and replenish themselves. So, for two months, I was not training. I was doing a lot of things that I've not done all these years. Small things like going out shopping with my wife or sitting with my dad and having tea or coffee in the evening. And then days where I'm not actually doing anything and just having conversations and discussions. I feel a lot more excited to watch squash now, and I think that's good. For the next few months, I won't be playing as much squash. Instead, I'll focus more on physical training. This will prepare me for when I start playing more in late August or early September. I have three months before the World Teams in December, so I want to be in a good position and not have to start from scratch. This way, I can focus on my squash game right away. Squash is a game where you can hit the ball very well, but it doesn't help if you don't get to the ball.

It must be a challenge for your coach as well to train somebody who has retired from PSA but still wants to play for the country. Did they recommend not retiring and just scaling back on PSA?

If I'm playing PSA, I'm playing to be the best I can be and have the highest ranking that I can have. Given the way the PSA is structured,

you have to play a minimum of 15 tournaments a year to be able to do that. Add the tournaments for India, and you're talking 7-18 tournaments a year. It's almost impossible to cut it down. The other option is that I don't push for all events, but I go all out for a few. However, my makeup from the start is that if I step on the court, I can't not push.

This new reality is now an experiment, both for me and for my team. Just because it's not been done before doesn't mean it cannot be done now. We're going to do everything we can. We'll prepare the best we can like I've always done, and then once you've controlled all these controllables, we'll leave it to the uncontrollables to take care of themselves.

How much of a temptation or motivation is that opportunity to be an Olympian, given there's no guarantee of the sport's future in the charter after LA?

I'd be lying if I said that the Olympics was not on my mind. Being an Olympian is a big honour for any sportsperson. I am working right now to be in the best possible shape for December for the World Teams. And then we go to the next one, which is the Asian Individual Championships (May, June 2025), and then we go to the World Cup (next December), which is in Chennai. Then there's the Asian Games and the Commonwealth Games in 2026. If I feel like I am producing a level of play that is going to get me to the Olympics, then we have a discussion.